

01204211 Discrete Mathematics
Lecture 7a: Languages and regular expressions¹

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¹Based on lecture notes of *Models of Computation* course by Jeff Erickson.

What is computation?

Models of computations

Languages = specifications

Formal definition: strings

Intuitively, a string is a *finite* sequence of symbols. However, to be able to formally prove properties of strings we need a precise definition.

Let a finite set Σ be the **alphabet**. (E.g., for bit strings, $\Sigma = \{0, 1\}$; for digits, $\Sigma = \{0, 1, \dots, 9\}$; for English string $\Sigma = \{a, b, \dots, z\}$.)

The following is a recursive definition of strings.

Recursive definition of strings

A **string** w over alphabet Σ is either

- ▶ the empty string ε , or
- ▶ $a \cdot x$ where $a \in \Sigma$ and x is a string.

The set of all strings over alphabet Σ is denoted by Σ^* .

Review: more recursive definitions

Lengths

For a string w , let $|w|$ be the length of w defined as

$$|w| = \begin{cases} 0 & \text{when } w = \varepsilon \\ 1 + |x| & \text{when } w = a \cdot x \end{cases}$$

Concatenation

For strings w and z , the concatenation $w \cdot z$ is defined recursively as

$$w \cdot z = \begin{cases} z & \text{when } w = \varepsilon \\ a \cdot (x \cdot z) & \text{when } w = a \cdot x \end{cases}$$

Review: proving facts about strings

Lemma 1

For strings w and x , $|w \bullet x| = |w| + |x|$.

Proof.



Formal languages

A **formal language** is a set of strings over some finite alphabet Σ .

Examples:

Careful...

These are different languages: $\emptyset, \{\varepsilon\}$

And ε is not a language.

How to describe languages?

Composition

Combining languages

If A and B are languages over alphabet Σ .

► Basic set operations: $A \cup B$, $A \cap B$, $\bar{A} = \Sigma^* \setminus A$.

► Concatenation: $A \cdot B$.

► Kleene closure or Kleene star: A^* .

Also $A^+ = A \cdot A^*$

Examples

Regular languages

Definition: regular languages

A language L is **regular** if and only if it satisfies one of the following conditions:

- ▶ L is empty;
- ▶ L contains one string (can be the empty string ε);
- ▶ L is a union of two regular languages;
- ▶ L is the concatenation of two regular languages; or
- ▶ L is the Kleene closure of a regular language.

Examples

Regular expressions

Let $\Sigma = \{0, 1\}$. Consider

$$((\{01\} \cup (\{1\} \cdot (\{0\} \cup \{10\}))) \cup (\{00\} \cdot (\{1\})^*)) \cdot ((\{0\} \cdot \{0\}) \cdot \{1\})$$

Regular expressions

Regular language

$$((\{01\} \cup (\{1\} \cdot (\{0\} \cup \{10\}))) \cup (\{00\} \cdot (\{1\})^*)) \cdot ((\{0\} \cdot \{0\}) \cdot \{1\})$$

is represented as

$$(01 + 1(0 + 10) + 00(1)^*)001$$

Regular expressions

- ▶ omit braces around one-string sets
- ▶ use $+$ instead of $\cup$
- ▶ omit $\cdot$
- ▶ follow the precedence: Kleene star operator $*$, $\cdot$ (implicitly), and $+$.

Remark: $+$ and $\cdot$ are associative, i.e., $(A + B) + C = A + (B + C)$ and $(A \cdot B) \cdot C = A \cdot (B \cdot C)$.

Regular expressions: examples 1

Regular expressions: examples 2

All strings over $\{0, 1\}$ except 010.

Subexpressions

Regex is everywhere

Proofs about regular expressions - structural induction

Lemma 2

Every regular expression that does not use the symbol $\emptyset$ represents a non-empty language.

Proof.

Let R be a regular expression that does not use the symbol $\emptyset$. We prove by (structural) induction that R represents a non-empty language.

Induction hypothesis: Every subexpression of R that does not use the symbol $\emptyset$ represents a non-empty language.

Case 1: $R = \emptyset$.

Case 2: R is a single string.

Proof. (cont.2/4)

Case 3: $R = S + T$ for some regular expressions S and T .

Proof. (cont.3/4)

Case 4: $R = S \cdot T$ for some regular expressions S and T .

Proof. (cont.4/4)

Case 5: $R = S^*$ for some regular expression S .

In every case, the language $L(R)$ is non-empty.

Lemma 3

Every non-empty regular language is represented by a regular expression that does not use the symbol $\emptyset$.

Let R be a regular expression. We prove that if $L(R) \neq \emptyset$, then there exists a regular expression R' such that $L(R) = L(R')$ and R' does not contain $\emptyset$.

We prove by induction. What should the induction hypothesis be?

I.H.: For every subexpression S of R , if $L(S) \neq \emptyset$, there exists an $\emptyset$ -free regular expression S' such that $L(S) = L(S')$.

What are the cases that we have to consider?

- ▶ $R = \emptyset$
- ▶ R is a single string.
- ▶ $R = S + T$ for some regular expressions S and T .
- ▶ $R = S \cdot T$ for some regular expressions S and T .
- ▶ $R = S^*$ for some regular expression S .

(E-ex1-6) For string w , the reversal w^R is defined recursively as follows:

$$w^R = \begin{cases} \varepsilon & \text{if } w = \varepsilon \\ x^R \cdot a & \text{if } w = ax \text{ for some symbol } a \text{ and some string } x \end{cases}$$

For a language L , the reversal of L is defined as

$$L^R = \{w^R \mid w \in L\}.$$

You may assume the following facts.

- ▶ $L^* \cdot L^* = L^*$ for every language L .
- ▶ $(w^R)^R = w$ for every string w .
- ▶ $(x \cdot y)^R = y^R \cdot x^R$ for all strings x and y .

Prove that $(L^R)^* \subseteq (L^*)^R$.